EDUCATIONAL CASE STUDY

SecureShield

Strategic Assessment

Investigating market share decline
and digital competitiveness

12% → 9%

Market share over two years in the fictional case scenario
3 percentage points lower | approximately 25% relative decline

Educational case study | IBM Management Consultant Professional Certificate coursework

Prepared as a course project for portfolio presentation on GitHub. SecureShield is a fictional client. This document is an educational exercise, not a real consulting engagement or an IBM-endorsed client deliverable.

PROBLEM ANALYSIS / APPROACH / ETHICS / EXECUTIVE OUTLINE

OVERVIEW & PART 1

Executive summary

A preliminary assessment and a proposed diagnostic - no verified root-cause findings.

SecureShield Insurance is a fictional regional Property and Casualty insurer operating across five U.S. states. In the case scenario, market share falls from 12% to 9% over two years, a decline of 3 percentage points, or approximately 25% relative to its previous position. This may weaken its competitive position as digital-first InsurTech competitors gain ground.

The problem to investigate

The primary problem is classified as technological: digital-first competitors offer faster, more customer-specific and technology-enabled services. SecureShield's digital workflows, presentation and customer experience are therefore priority areas for investigation. Strategic investment prioritization and operational efficiency are important secondary dimensions.

Proposed response

Use a ten-week diagnostic to identify the principal drivers of market share loss and develop a feasible, evidence-based strategic response. Compare internal transformation, technology partnerships and acquisition before selecting a preferred option. No strategic option is recommended as a proven solution at this stage.

Key investigative questions

- At which stages of the customer journey does SecureShield underperform against digital-first competitors, particularly in policy acquisition, customer service and claims processing?
- To what extent do IT capabilities, staffing levels and technology investment constrain digital competitiveness?
- Which customer segments and geographic markets show the greatest erosion? How strongly is it associated with digital expectations versus pricing or product differences?

Evidence boundary
Market share and competitive pressure are scenario inputs. Internal weaknesses and causal links are hypotheses. No interviews, proprietary data analysis, validated findings or measured results are claimed.

PART 1 / PROBLEM ANALYSIS

Five Whys: a hypothesis chain

An exploratory sequence to test, not an established explanation of the decline.

01 / Competitive pressure

SCENARIO PREMISE

Digital-first InsurTech competitors are gaining ground by offering faster and more customer-centric insurance services.

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02 / Customer platform

HYPOTHESIS

SecureShield may lack an efficient, user-friendly digital platform, making it harder and slower to obtain information, purchase policies and submit claims.

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03 / Technology capacity

HYPOTHESIS

The IT department may be understaffed, limiting its ability to develop, modernize and maintain a competitive digital customer platform.

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04 / Investment constraints

HYPOTHESIS

A reduced IT budget may have limited the ability to retain skilled technology professionals.

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05 / Strategic priorities

HYPOTHESIS

Management may have prioritized short-term cost reduction over long-term digital investment because a clear digital transformation strategy was absent.

Validation requirement: Test every link with customer, operational, technology and financial evidence. Investigate alternative explanations, including pricing, product positioning and customer segment dynamics.

PART 2 / APPROACH & PLAN

A ten-week diagnostic roadmap

Lead specialty: Digital Transformation Consulting, supported by Strategy and Operations Consulting.



01 Discovery — Weeks 1-2

Conduct stakeholder interviews, define the problem scope, assess data availability and refine initial hypotheses.

Deliverable: Diagnostic framework and data inventory

02 Analysis — Weeks 3-6

Evaluate acquisition and retention, digital customer journeys, claims performance, IT capabilities and competitor positioning.

Deliverable: Evidence-based root-cause assessment

03 Strategy — Weeks 7-8

Develop response options and assess expected impact, costs, feasibility and risks.

Deliverable: Prioritized strategic options

04 Roadmap — Weeks 9-10

Define implementation priorities, milestones, responsibilities, KPIs and investment requirements.

Deliverable: Executive recommendation and implementation roadmap

Engagement objective
Identify the principal drivers of declining market share and recommend a feasible, evidence-based strategic response.

PART 2 / EVIDENCE PLAN

Data required to test the case

The following inputs would be requested during the proposed diagnostic; availability has not been confirmed.

Customer & market

Customer acquisition, churn and retention; market share by state and customer segment.

Digital performance

Online conversion rates, digital channel adoption, website performance and customer satisfaction / NPS.

Operational performance

Claims processing cycle times, service response times and cost-to-serve by channel.

Technology & finance

IT budgets, staffing capacity, technology architecture and modernization costs.

Competitive intelligence

Publicly available competitor pricing, product features, digital capabilities and market benchmarks.

How evidence informs the decision
Use these inputs to distinguish confirmed drivers from preliminary hypotheses and compare the options on strategic impact, investment, speed, feasibility and risk. No numerical targets or financial benefits are assumed in this case study.

PART 3 / STAKEHOLDER & ETHICS MEMO

Stakeholders, trust and integrity

To: SecureShield Executive Leadership | From: Educational case-study team

Chief Actuary

Responsible for actuarial risk assessment, pricing adequacy and financial resilience. Key concern: whether digital transformation and changes in acquisition could harm underwriting profitability or the company's risk profile.

Agency partners

Independent agents and brokers distribute SecureShield's products. Key concerns: channel displacement, commission losses and weaker customer relationships if direct-to-consumer digital sales expand.

Policyholders

Customers depend on coverage and reliable claims settlement. Key concerns: competitive pricing, data privacy, service accessibility and efficient claims processing.

Ethical dilemma in the scenario

During the competitive assessment, a team member is informally offered confidential pricing information belonging to an InsurTech competitor. Using it could create an unfair competitive advantage and potentially violate confidentiality obligations or applicable competition laws.

Recommended resolution

Decline to receive or use improperly disclosed confidential information. Document the incident and consult the firm's ethics or legal function where appropriate. Rely on lawfully obtained public information, authorized market research and legitimate industry benchmarks. This protects client trust, professional integrity and the independence of the assessment.

PART 4 / FIVE-SLIDE EXECUTIVE OUTLINE

Frame the executive decision

Fictional client: SecureShield Insurance | Preliminary Strategic Assessment | Audience: CEO and Executive Leadership Team

01 / Market share has declined by 25% relatively

- Market share decreased from 12% to 9% over two years: 3 percentage points, or approximately 25% relative to the previous position.
- Digital-first InsurTech competitors increase competitive pressure through faster, more customer-centric services. The decline raises concerns about long-term competitiveness.

Key message: A structured diagnostic is required before selecting a strategic response.

02 / Digital competitiveness is a priority hypothesis

- Potential gaps include digital customer experience, policy acquisition and claims processing. Technology capabilities, staffing and investment priorities may contribute.
- Investigate alternative explanations, including pricing, product positioning and customer segment dynamics.

Key message: Competitive pressure is a scenario premise; SecureShield's specific internal weaknesses and root causes remain unverified.

03 / Compare three strategic options

A / Build - Internal digital transformation
Modernize customer platforms and internal workflows; strengthen technology capabilities and employee training. Greater control, with potentially higher implementation effort and longer timelines.

B / Partner - Technology and InsurTech partnerships
Use external providers for digital distribution, claims automation or customer service. Potentially faster access to capabilities, with vendor dependency and integration risks.

C / Buy - Strategic acquisition
Evaluate a suitable technology business or digital insurance capability. Potentially accelerated capability acquisition, with capital requirements and integration complexity.

Key message: Compare strategic impact, investment, speed, feasibility and risk before recommending an option.

PART 4 / FIVE-SLIDE EXECUTIVE OUTLINE

Validate, prioritize and decide

Continuation of the executive presentation outline

04 / Use data to validate strategic priorities

- **Customer:** Acquisition, churn, retention, NPS and digital channel adoption.
- **Operations:** Claims processing times, service performance and cost-to-serve.
- **Technology:** IT architecture, staffing, budgets and system integration constraints.
- **Market:** Competitive positioning, public pricing, product features and market share by state and segment.

Key message: Evidence-based analysis will distinguish confirmed drivers from preliminary hypotheses.

05 / Deliver a recommendation within ten weeks

- **Weeks 1-2 / Discovery:** Stakeholder interviews, problem scoping and data assessment.
- **Weeks 3-6 / Analysis:** Customer, operational, technology and competitor diagnostics.
- **Weeks 7-8 / Strategy:** Evaluate alternatives, business impact, costs and risks.
- **Weeks 9-10 / Roadmap:** Prioritized initiatives, implementation milestones, KPIs and governance.

Expected outcome: A validated root-cause assessment, strategic options evaluation and an actionable digital transformation roadmap. These are proposed deliverables, not completed findings.

EXECUTIVE DECISION REQUESTED

Approve the proposed diagnostic scope, nominate an executive sponsor and authorize access to the required data.

Coursework note: Adapted from the original SecureShield strategic assessment. The four original parts are preserved and reorganized for portfolio presentation. The executive summary synthesizes that material; no new research findings or achieved outcomes are introduced.